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Alain Patrick Olivier

The Power of Music: Women and Resistance[1]

I. Introduction

In a famous scene from Luchino Visconti's film *Senso*, during a performance of Giuseppe Verdi's *Il Trovatore*, the Italian spectators—men and women—standing in the upper tiers of the theater, defy the Austrian occupiers, the officers seated in the parterre, by flooding the auditorium with bouquets and twirling tricolored leaflets. This occurs just as the Italian tenor, sword in hand, completes his martial aria of bravery on stage:

> *Di quella pira l'orrendo foco*
>
> *Tutte le fibre m'arse avvampò...*

We see here the role played by Italian opera in the process of Italian liberation, even though the scene doesn't take place in Hegel's time nor in the Teatro San Carlo in Naples, but at La Fenice in Venice, during the Venetians' uprising against the Austrian occupiers in 1866.

The period of the Restoration following the Congress of Vienna in 1815 was intended to end Napoleon's reign, to halt French domination, and to suppress revolutionary movements in Europe. Ferdinand IV returned to the throne in Naples. After a brief republican experiment and the *decennio francese* (1806-1809), this restoration of the Bourbons led to

[1] This article revisits elements presented in Naples at the Istituto degli Studi Filosofici and published in Italian in a collective volume: Giulia Battistoni, Francesco Campana, Mildred Galland, Francesca Iannelli, Alain Patrick Olivier, and Federica Pitillo (Eds.), *Manoscritti degli uditori dell'Università di Berlino: nuove traduzioni, sfide e prospettive di ricerca sui corsi di Estetica di G.W.F. Hegel / Cahiers d'auditeurs à l'Université de Berlin: nouvelles traductions, défis et perspectives de recherche sur les cours d'esthétique de G.W.F. Hegel,* IISF Press, 2025. It was also presented in lectures given on July 2, 2024, at the Hegel Now! event at the Università Roma 3; August 2024 at the World Congress of Philosophy, University La Sapienza (Panel: Theory and Translation Practice: Challenges, Intentions, and Outcomes of the International Network "Hegel Art Net"); January 2025 at the Marc Bloch Centre in Berlin.

violent clashes with Republicans and Liberals. This does not mean, however, that we are dealing with a period of historical closure; it was a time of opposition and rebellion, of the struggle for freedom. It was the period of the *carbonari*, politically speaking, when the Liberals formed an opposition in Italy. Austria crushed the insurrection defending a constitutional monarchy in 1821.

The French philosopher Victor Cousin read *La révolution piémontaise* by Santa-Rosa (leader of the Piedmontese reformist party). In 1824, he was dismissed from his courses in Paris and arrested during a trip to Germany. He was imprisoned in Berlin, but his friend and colleague Hegel intervened to secure his release. In the same year, Hegel traveled to Vienna to hear the Neapolitan singers, and Stendhal published *La vie de Rossini*, which was soon translated into German by the Hegelian Amadeus Wendt under the title *Rossini's Leben und Treiben*. Stendhal wrote that after Napoleon's fall, Rossini was the man talked about in all the capitals of Europe.

One could argue that Hegel's "attention to the *mezzogiorno*," like that of later Naples Hegelians and Gramsci, is not entirely unrelated to the political and revolutionary question[2]. In any case, the reverse is also true: from the 1840s onward, Hegel's philosophy began permeating political and national consciousness, spreading through academic and revolutionary circles in Naples. It is also at this time that Hegel's works began to be translated, including his aesthetics lectures, published by his student Hotho[3]. Bertrando Spaventa writes:

[2] Cf. Barbagallo, Francesco. "Il Mezzogiorno, Lo Stato e Il Capitalismo Italiano Dalla 'Quistione Meridionale' Ai 'Quaderni Del Carcere.'" *Studi Storici*, vol. 29, no. 1, 1988, pp. 21–42. *JSTOR*, http://www.jstor.org/stable/20565805.

[3] Cf Francesca Iannelli, Alain Patrick Olivier, « En traduisant Hegel, Traducendo Hegel, Aesthetic theory and/in Translation practice », *Studi di Estetica,* anno L, 1/ 2002.

> *In Napoli sin dal 1843 l'idea hegeliana penetrò nelle menti de' giovani cultori della scienza, i quali mossi come da santo amore si affratellavano, e con la voce e gli scritti la predicavano. Né i sospetti già desti della polizia, aizzati dall'ignoranza e dall'ipocrisia religiosa, né le minacce e le persecuzioni valsero ad infievolire la fede in questi arditi difensori della indipendenza del pensiero; i numerosi studenti raccolti da tutti i punti del Regno nella grande capitale disertavano le vecchie cattedre, ed accorrevano in folla ad ascoltare la nuova parola*[4].

The phenomenon of Italian opera is often judged superficial—merely entertainment, barely art—whether by contemporaries like Hotho or by modern theorists. The reception of Hegel's philosophy is often misunderstood in its logical, metaphysical, or political dimensions, even though it could be argued that we must rescue Hegel from panlogicism, historicism, or a restorative attitude. We know that Hegel, throughout his life, took a stance in favor of the Revolution and the French Army, even opposing the Prussian Army at Valmy, Jena, and even at Waterloo[5].

But is there a "speculative" or political dimension to Rossini's music? Or is this an absence on the part of the philosopher—an example of his "amusia" when attempting to theorize and perform such phenomena? What makes the comparison between Rossini's music and the system of Hegel's philosophy possible and attractive is Hegel's general idea that art and philosophy share the same content. We must thus pose this admittedly paradoxical equation: Rossini's music and Hegel's philosophy have the same content; only the form is different.

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[4] Cf. Barbagallo, Francesco. "Il Mezzogiorno, Lo Stato e Il Capitalismo Italiano Dalla 'Quistione Meridionale' Ai 'Quaderni Del Carcere.'" *Studi Storici*, vol. 29, no. 1, 1988, pp. 21–42. *JSTOR*, http://www.jstor.org/stable/20565805.

[5] Alain Patrick Olivier, « Hegel et la Révolution française ». *France-Allemagne*, Anne Baillot & Ayşe Yuva (Eds.), Presses universitaires du Septentrion, 2014, https://doi.org/10.4000/books.septentrion.62728.

My hypothesis is that this content is none other than *freedom*, the consciousness of freedom, and absolute freedom. This could lead us to think of absolute knowledge in relation to nature, vitality, and the body. But we will focus on the political dimension since, in the 1820s, the notion of freedom was also—and perhaps above all—a political notion.

Because this is not explicitly stated in Hegel's texts, we will read it through a shifted lens, akin to that of the Young Hegelians, who saw the aesthetics lectures as a critique of religion and politics[6]. Left Hegelians, such as Eduard Gans, Bruno Bauer and Karl Marx, supported opposition, rebellion and revolution, while Right Hegelians, such as Heinrich Gustav Hotho and Leopold Henning, supported German culture, the German monarchy, and the established order[7]. This opposition is not merely political or philosophical; it also concerns the very interpretation of Hegel's texts and the function of aesthetics in relation to politics. Given the political, aesthetic, and scientific censorship of the period, art and aesthetic criticism can be seen as fields through which liberal or revolutionary political positions were indirectly expressed.

It is not only Hegel's philosophy of law that should be considered from this perspective; his philosophy of art can also offer a mediated conception of politics, especially through its treatment of the concepts of freedom and absolute spirit.

In order to show the common emancipatory content between Rossini's music and Hegel's philosophy, we will analyze Hegel's references to Italian artists in the letters written to his wife from a political perspective (ii) and then compare this with developments in the 1828-1829 Aesthetics lectures, particularly in the chapter on music (iii). A marginal remark by

[6] Gabriele Schimmenti, *L'arte contesa. L'estetica, la sinistra hegeliana e il giovane Marx,* Editore Orthotes 2021. – See also : Ingrid Pepperle, *Junghegelianische Geschichtsphilosphie und Kunsttheorie.* Berlin, Akademie Verlag, 1978. – Douglas Moggach (Ed.), *Politics, Religion, and Art : Hegelian Debates,* Northowestern University Press, 2011.

[7] Eduard Gans explicitly introduced for the first time a 'theory of opposition' in his 1828/29 lectures on natural law. See Norbert Wazek, « L'émergence d'une théorie de l'opposition dans l'école hégélienne ». *Revue Française d'Histoire des Idées Politiques,* 25(1), 2007, 89-107.https://doi.org/10.3917/rfhip.025.0089.

Hegel, found in Libelt's notebook, concerning a passage from *La Gazza Ladra* by Rossini, will serve as an example of how aesthetics, in the sense of "l'art pour l'art," can interact with political content (iv).

It is notable that the only living women mentioned in Hegel's *Aesthetics* are singers, specifically Italian singers: Angelica Catalani and Gentile Borgondio, cited in the 1820-1821 lectures[8]. Their names do not appear in Hotho's edition, but only in Ascheberg's notebook. For us, the issue is not just the relationship between philosophy and music, or between Germanic philosophers and Italian artists, but also the relationship between philosophers and living women. We will conclude on the power of music and the resistance of artists, particularly Italian singers, with a comparison between Angelica Catalani and Floria Tosca, the heroine of Puccini's opera (v).

II. Göttliche Furore

Aesthetically speaking, the period of the *decennio francese* in Naples brought about significant transformations in the world of theatre and music, particularly with the decision to abolish the use of castrati in conservatories and the establishment of a conservatory for women[9]. This period saw the development of women's participation in singing, allowing them to perform male roles, or *drag* (travestito), such as Gentile Borgondio singing the role of Tancredi or Angelica Catalani performing Malcolm in *La Donna del Lago*. The political decision to end this practice eventually led to the development and expansion of tenor roles, as seen in Rossini's *Otello*. This marked the beginning of the reign of the modern tenor.

[8] Cf Francesca Iannelli, Alain Patrick Olivier, « En traduisant Hegel, Traducendo Hegel, Aesthetic theory and/in Translation practice », *Studi di Estetica,* anno L, 1/ 2002.

[9] See Damien Colas Gallet et Alessandro Di Profico (Eds.), *L'Opéra à Naples et à Paris sous le* decennio francese *(1806-1815),* Paris, Presses Sorbonne Nouvelle, 2021.

Rossini's fame reached Naples in 1814. Thanks to the theatre director Domenico Barbaja, the connection between Naples and Rossini proved to be fruitful: ten of his operas were performed in Naples between 1815 and 1822 (not to mention his sacred music and cantatas). From 1822 to 1828, Barbaja also organized an Italian opera season in Vienna every summer. Hegel refers to this in his letters from 1824. It was during this time that Hegel encountered the following operas in Vienna: *Doralice* by Mercadante; *Otello*, *Zelmira*, *Corradino*, *Il Barbiere di Siviglia* by Gioachino Rossini; and *Le Nozze di Figaro* by Wolfgang Amadeus Mozart. Hegel debates whether it is good or bad taste to prefer Rossini's *Figaro* to Mozart's, noting that one is Italian and the other Austrian, which could also suggest a political preference.

Hegel also attended a ballet performance with music by Rossini. In Paris at the Théâtre Italien and in Berlin at various theaters, he had the opportunity to hear additional operas by Rossini, including *Tancredi* sung by Gentile Borgondio and, most likely, *La Gazza Ladra*. In his Viennese letters, Hegel mentions the following singers: sopranos Joséphine Fodor and Girolama Dardanelli-Corradi, contralto Fanny Eckerlin, and tenors Giovanni David, Domenico Donzelli, and Battista Rubini (the three tenors performed together in *Otello*). Hegel also heard basses such as Luigi Lablache, Antonio Ambrogi (who originated the role of Podestà in *La Gazza Ladra*), and Luigi Bassi (who had created the role of Don Giovanni in Prague for W. A. Mozart).

In all of Hegel's accounts, however, there is no consideration of the dramatic content—whether the tragedies or comedies adapted from Shakespeare, Voltaire, or Beaumarchais. Instead, Hegel focuses on the talent of the performers. In his judgments, he describes the qualities of the voice: power (*Stärke*, *Kraft*, *Macht*), purity (*Reinheit*), even the timbre (*Metall*), and sonority (*Klang*). The categories of Hegel's *Naturphilosophie* are employed to describe the power of Italian singers. Furthermore, Hegel is obviously concerned with

vocal technique and admires cultivated voices, which demonstrate *Ausbildung* (training) and the taste (*Geschmack*) exhibited by the performer. But the art of singing, for Hegel, refers to expression: "passion" (*Leidenschaft*) and, above all, "freedom" (*Freiheit*) are the supreme categories. Hegel calls the “divine fury” (*göttliche Furore*) the “melodic storm” (*melodischer Strom*) that “animates, penetrates, and frees each situation” (*Situation*) [10].

Beyond the intrinsic beauty of the timbre and the power of expression, the male and female singers are also actors and actresses. Some of them, like Donzelli and Lablache, with their beards and black curls, are compared to Greek statues, representing the living heads of ancient marbles:

> *bärtig mit schwarzen Locken, welche antike Köpfe, jener ein beginnender, dieser ein reifer Mann, man könnte sie jeder antiken Statue aufsetzen*[11].

We are confronted with sculptures that have found their gaze, their form, their expression, and their voice. While tragic actors—whose singing was merely declamation—covered themselves with masks, Italian male and female singers combine the beautiful exterior of the ancient figure with the interiority of the Romantic soul, expressed through their voices, making them individuals.

The category of individuality, particularly beautiful individuality or free individuality, is also a category that Hegel employs in his *Philosophy of History*, where it is related to the Greek people and Greek democracy[12]. These singers are also subjectivities who externalize themselves. The supreme quality of Italian singers, however, remains their inventiveness in

[10] Hegel an seine Frau, 4. Okt. 1824, in *Briefe von und an Hegel,* éd. J. Hoffmeister, Hamburg, Meiner, 1969, p. 71.

[11] Ibid.

[12] Cf. Fiorinda Li Vigni, “Hegel et la démocratie athénienne”, *Pensée : revue éditée par la Fondation Gabriel Péri,* 378, Avril-Juin, 2014, 41-50.

the production of expression and coloratura, which manifests their true creative power. These ornaments and additions, far from being superfluous, are the moments in which the singers truly shine and can use the full range of their voices, in which they can "let themselves go freely" (*das freie Ergehen im Singen*).

These are the categories Hegel uses to describe Rossini's music and Italian singers. It is a kind of improvisation in which the singers become the true composers. It is a manifestation of freedom, understood as the *Beisichsein* of the spirit in the naturalness, corporeality, and organicity of the voice—of the instrument. It is a form of awareness of freedom, of free subjectivity, of absolute subjectivity. The singers show the processes of composition, in contrast to performers, actors, and singers who merely perform music that has already been written. The performers, then, are not merely the contingent agents of music's execution; they are the real artists through whom the music acquires its meaning. They are the essential element of the performance. Thus, the question is not *who* composed the music, but *who sings it* and *how* it is sung. Through their performance, the singers realize a form of individuality and present the very notion of subjectivity in Hegel's aesthetics.

III. The Concrete Subjectivity

In Hegel's lectures, the concrete subjectivity, which constitutes music in its truth, takes three forms: that of the spectator, that of the composer, and that of the virtuoso artist. The audience is constituted as the instance that knows precisely how to determine what is musical amidst the non-musical. Hegel is referring here to his experience of the Italian opera audience, which knows how to regard the external dramatic element for what it is, i.e., as a pretext for the emergence of the melodic — as an inessential and external element — in order to focus on the musical moment specifically when it appears.

> *Das Publikum macht sich nun bald vom äusseren Inhalte los und hält sich an das eigentlich Musikalische. Eine Forderung die auch der Italiener macht, wir nicht. Der Italiener spricht und isst beim Rezitativ, passt auf bei dem eigentlich Musikalischen*[13].

The Italian audience behaves authentically towards the musical work because the musical work has no consistency of its own. On the contrary, it is essentially an address to others. The audience knows that the musical work exists for them, and that they are its true center. German audiences, on the other hand, regard the work as a thing in itself — as an object of veneration — and feel themselves to be inessential and somewhat out of place as a perceptual instance. They are not interested in their own engagement or satisfaction but in the artwork in front of them, in which they seek to dissolve themselves.

The second subjective instance in music is that of the composer. Here, the truth of music as a free exercise of subjectivity emerges. The content of instrumental music is not to be found in an objective element external to it, but rather in the very form of its activity — in the act of composing. This music, quite simply, is music "that is only about the subject," that expresses nothing other than itself, and that has no purpose other than to serve as a pretext for the composer to give free rein to his imagination, independent of any constraints linked to the text. The composer is therefore completely free to produce the material for his work on his own.

> *Diese freie Willkür Phantasien zu zeigen ist Zweck. Er (Der Künstler) kann bekannte Melodien verweben und zum Heterogensten fortschreiten*[14].

[13] G. W. F. Hegel, *Vorlesungen zur Ästhetik,* ed. A. P. Olivier, A. Gethmann-Siefert, München, Fink, 2017, p. 186.

[14] *Op. cit.,* p. 178.

However, the composer is not the supreme subjective authority in the work of art. After the listener and the composer, it is the interpreter's intervention that is recognized as "linked to the effective reality of the musical work," as we read in the chapter on music in the 1829 lectures. The interpreter is the "brilliant artist" who "easily tends to appear as if composing during the performance, as Rossini made it easy for his singers to do."

> *Der Künstler geräth leicht darin, in der Exekution als selbst komponierend zu erscheinen, wie es Rossini dem Künstler leicht gemacht hat, selbst sich zu zeigen. Ein melodisches Ergehen zeigt sich dann auch in der Melodie besonders; ist so die Freiheit des Sängers überwiegend, so hat man da künstlerische Wirken vor sich; das Produzierende selbst interessiert dann in der lebendigen Gegenwart; alles Bedingende ist verschwunden wie die Bedingungen der Kirche und des Inhalts der dramatischen Musik. Die gegenwärtige Seele lässt des Textes entbehren*[15].

The artist easily finds himself in a position where, in execution, he appears as if composing himself — as Rossini made it easy for his singers to reveal themselves. This melodic freedom, particularly evident in the melody, shows that the freedom of the singer predominates, thus revealing the artistic process itself. What matters in this moment is the *productive character* itself, present in its living form. All external conditions, such as those of the church or the content of dramatic music, disappear. The present soul no longer needs the text.

This statement seems to paraphrase one of the letters that the enthusiastic philosopher wrote to his wife at the beginning of his stay in Vienna. Here, the objectivity of the musical work

[15] Op. cit., p. 187

of art dissolves entirely and becomes a veritable improvisation, in which "the freedom of the singer is predominant." There is no content here that holds value beyond the immediate expressive action. We are no longer dealing with an objective work of art, as in painting or sculpture, but with *artistic activity* itself — with *the productive character* itself, in its living presence.

IV. Rossini's Speculative Sentence

Let us explore more precisely, with an example, how the experience of Italian singers is discussed in Hegel's Aesthetics lectures. There is a passage in Karl Libelt's notebook referring explicitly to the Rossini debates[16]. The question arises as to whether opera should be regarded primarily as a drama, in which the text plays a predominant role, or whether the action and declamation themselves should be subject to the free development of the musical element. This is essentially the dividing line between the proponents of Italian opera and those of German opera. In Hegel's time, this polemic took the form of a debate for or against Rossini. In a margin of Libelt's notebook, we can read:

> *Der Streit zwischen Glucks und Piccinis Musik war heftig, wie heute für und gegen Rossini gesprochen wird. Seine Musik ist gefühlsvoll, was dem deutschen strengen Charakter zuwider ist. In der Inquisitionszene der diebischen Elster von Rossini singt der Criminalrichter im freiesten Ergehen der Melodie*[17].

[16] I commented this passage earlier but I would like to give a different interpretation including a political meaning. Alain Patrick Olivier, *Hegel et la musique: de l'expérience esthétique à la speculation philosophique,* Paris, Champion, 2003.

[17] GW 28, 3 , S. 1141. – Hegel, *Vorlesungen zur Ästhetik*, op cit, p. 187.

What is Hegel referring to here? Which debates and which moment in the opera? Hegel (or Libelt) speaks of the “Kriminalrichter”. There are different characters in *La gazza ladra*: Pretore (“grand prévôt” in the French version) and Podestà (“bailli du village”). We could assume that Hegel is referring to the *Podestà*. This interpretation aligns with Hegel’s description of the melody, as the *Pretore* only pronounces the sentence without any melodic embellishment, and the *Podestà* was indeed a subject of debate in Milan at the time, and perhaps the same was true in Naples, Vienna, and Berlin. To explore this further, we will reference Stendhal's book and his chapter on *La Gazza ladra*, especially since Stendhal attempted the first performance of the opera in Milan in 1817, describing the debates, the singers' art, and the reactions of the audience, particularly those related to the character of the *Podestà*.

Stendhal explains that *La gazza ladra* (in French, *La pie voleuse*) was originally a “mélodrame du boulevard” in Paris, a “nasty story” (“un vrai drame noir et plat”), “based on reality”: the reality being that a servant was hanged in Palaiseau for stealing a spoon. This is the cruel reality. How does the work of art relate to this reality?

Stendhal distinguishes three attitudes towards reality: that of the Germans, that of the French, and that of the Italians. The Germans "like to spend the thirty or forty years for which chance has placed them in this sad cage counting the bars”; they “believe in ghosts and the miracles of Prince Hohenlohe, and would be delighted with the degree of darkness that reality adds to the drama of *La Pie voleuse*." This position does not correspond to Hegel's, but rather to the romantic position he criticizes in his lectures. The Frenchman is a "man of taste" who says to himself: "this world is so ugly" that one must flee the "sad reality". He "asks the fine arts" for the "beautiful ideal" that will allow him to quickly forget this world of baseness. This position aligns well with Hegel's perspective. The Italian, on the other hand, "as soon as he can be freed from the priest who tormented his youth, does

not bother with such long reasonings; he would never manage, and the police of his country have, for centuries, prevented him from learning logic; he has passions, and he gives himself to them blindly. Rossini makes beautiful music for him on an abominable subject; he enjoys the music without paying too much attention to the subject … The Italian admits at most one kind of discussion, one that aims to double his pleasures right away and in cash." The music of Rossini, therefore, serves as a substitute for logic and reasoning. Pleasure and satisfaction take a more immediate form, that of aesthetics. Hegel's position, on the contrary, is to approach the matter like the French, based on logic and reasoning. In any case, Stendhal establishes the equivalence of the positions.

The debates focus notably on the role of the *Podestà* in the opera. Ninetta, the servant, is accused of stealing a small silver spoon. The interrogation is conducted by the *Podestà* in the first act. According to Stendhal, the music "recaptures all the lightness, all the gaiety possible, and even an elegance it hadn't had until then." The *Podestà* has the servant thrown into prison, hoping to buy her love. Then, in the second act, she appears before the court. In an initial interpretation, I particularly focused on this passage from the second act. The *Pretore* reads the death sentence in the form of a melodrama:

Considerando che la nominata

Ninetta Villabella è rea convinta

di domestico furto; a pieni voti,

ed a tenor delle vigenti leggi, il regio tribunale

la condanna alla pena capitale.

In the following vocal quintet, each of the characters present expresses their feelings: Ninetta, her fiancé Gianetto, Gianetto's father, and the *Podestà* (the Bailiff).

"Ahi, qual colpo!... Già d'intorno

sibilar la morte ascolto.

Già dipinto nel suo volto

miro il duolo ed il terror!"

One would expect a representation of violent feelings of pain and terror: this is what the dramatic situation and even the content of the words seem to demand. But the *Podestà* opens the ensemble with a melody full of ornaments. In this moment of agony, where the melodrama reaches its climax, Rossini composes the most florid and virtuosic melodic line, as if to express not pain but, on the contrary, the greatest joy.

Why does Rossini compose the Podestà's line this way? One interpretation is purely aesthetic. Even in the situation of greatest rupture, when the "content" seems favorable to the eruption of the non-beautiful and the characteristic, to the break in melodic plasticity, pure beautiful singing asserts its rights without restriction. Pure musical beauty seems a principle superior to dramatic demands, so one might see here a formalism of melody, an autonomy of song considered as an end in itself, an emancipation of the dramatic "content." Hegel asserts that Rossini's music is "full of feelings," but it seems that in this passage, the composer is precisely indifferent to the feeling of pain mentioned in the libretto, contradicting the fundamental principle that music should serve to express the passions.

However, the Podestà's melody can still be interpreted as justified by the dramatic situation, despite the literal meaning of the words. Indeed, it seems that the composer obeyed not only

a purely musical imperative but also a dramaturgical intuition in line with the semi-comic genre of this opera. The almost joyful indifference of the judge to the death of others can be interpreted as an anticipation of the happy resolution of the drama. Rossini, unlike Mozart, refuses to take pain and death seriously for both ethical and aesthetic reasons. Indifference to pain and death, or rather the presence of joy in pain and life in death, also corresponds to the very definition of the aesthetic ideal in Hegel and the conception of the human voice, especially Italian voices, such as the voice of Catalani. The use of melody in such a situation can be interpreted as a purely aesthetic need to sacrifice itself to beautiful singing, but it can also be seen as the expression of an idealization of passion, a liberation of the character from the very affection of which they are the victim.

Yet, Stendhal offers another interpretation. It is the satirical, political, or critical interpretation that he develops regarding the role of the *Podestà* as a judge in the scene of the interrogation in the first act:

> *Il est vrai que cette admirable légèreté, ce badinage aimable et tout à fait monarchique s'est rencontré plusieurs fois, en ces derniers temps, chez des juges, gens du monde, qui envoyaient à la mort les ennemis du pouvoir en se jouant, ou plutôt sans interrompre les jeux d'une vie aimable et insouciante*[18].

The lightness of the music would merely mirror the lightness with which justice is rendered. It would thereby take the form of social criticism.

> *Rossini, né en Romagne, et accoutumé aux juges nommés par des prêtres, a été peintre fidèle dans tout le rôle du Podestàt de la Gazza ladra. En mettant tant de gaieté, d'insouciance et de légèreté dans l'interrogatoire de Ninetta,*

[18] Stendhal, *Vie de Rossini, op. cit.,* p. 307.

> *Rossini avait en vue le personnage principal, ce vieux coquin scélérat et libertin, et il tient compte du dénouement de son opéra, qu'il savait devoir être di lieto fine comme ceux de Métastase*[19].

The criticisms made of Rossini regarding the character of the *Podestà* can be understood in the context of Lombardy, where "Napoleon had brought some decency to justice (1797 to 1814)." In this sense, the aesthetic debate concerns the representation of justice in the context of the Restoration. Rossini's music would amplify the criticism present in the drama, not by emphasizing the darkness of reality, but by highlighting the weight of lightness.

Rossini recalls the death of Cimarosa: "In Italy, at that time, go see in Ferrara, in Rimini, the judgments rendered there every day." This suggests that we could have a purely aesthetic interpretation, but also a political one according to the principles of realism and reality. Stendhal reminds us that Rossini's supporters, for whom there were two opposing parties in Italy and Germany, argue that he should be thanked for dissipating the atrocity of the subject with the lightness of his melodies. This would be the aesthetic view, the classical idealist interpretation, but one can also see a political meaning behind this passage, considering how Stendhal describes Rossini's supporters and opponents. He writes about the finale of the first act:

> *Mozart aurait rendu ce final atroce et tout à fait insupportable en prenant les mots au tragique : son âme tendre n'aurait pas manqué de se ranger du côté de Ninetta et de l'humanité au lieu de penser au Podestat et à ses projets plus libertins que sanguinaires*[20].

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[19] *Ibid.*

[20] *Ibid.*, p. 311.

The scene of the inquisition in *La Gazza ladra*, cited by Hegel in his 1829 lectures, exemplifies the arbitrariness of bailiffs and provosts, unjust and exorbitant punishment, or the spectacle of the helpless human being, present in these works. This seems related to the excerpts copied in the Steiger Library from the time of Bern regarding the drowning punishment for a young girl accused of having had an abortion (condemned to death for infanticide)[21]. If we consider that the French Revolution is the political-historical framework for the young Hegel (and perhaps still for the last Hegel), we also understand, in this sense and through this mediation, the equation that can be established between Italian opera and absolute knowledge.

V. **Angelica Catalani and Floria Tosca**

If we return to Angelica Catalani, we could consider the emancipation of working women and artists. We could also offer a political interpretation of Hegel's position. The idealist conception (art as absolute spirit) is not contradictory with a materialist, even revolutionary interpretation. The Italian singers are artists working for the aristocracy and the Austrian empire, but they also embody a sound, an image, and gestures of free consciousness, the absolute spirit, i.e., absolute power. To conclude, allow me to compare Hegel's conception of the singer, based on the art of Angelica Catalani, with the one found, for example, in Puccini's *Tosca*[22]. In the students' notebooks, the reference to Catalani appears in connection with the power of singing, and thus the power of music. Female singers represent a form of power. In *Tosca*, the singer is pious and in love with a revolutionary artist, Mario

[21] Chiara Magni , *La fonction dialectique de la peine,* Dissertation, Roma, Universita di Roma, 2024, p. 112.

[22] The study of Hegel's relationship with Angelica Catalani will be published at a later date as part of the research project *Hegel and the Constellations of the feminine,* https://www.hegel-femhab.org/– At the XXV International Philosophy Congress, in 2024, the participants were able to attend a performance of *La Tosca* given by the artists of the Rome Opera at the Terme di Caracalla.

Cavaradossi – potentially a Hegelian in the 19th-century sense – who supports Napoleon's victories and the opponents of the regime and is tortured by the police. Floria Tosca confronts the chief of police and kills him. Her song fails to move the chief of police, nor does she understand, caught up in her piety, the police machinations.

Nell'ora del dolore

Perchè, perchè, Signore

Ah, perchè me ne rimuneri cosi?

The singer is fooled by the chief of police, whom she will have killed, but she will also have betrayed the revolutionary's secret. The artist (the woman) in *Puccini* does not, therefore, possess a power and knowledge superior to that of the police or the state.

In Hegel, however, the situation is different. The artist possesses a power and a knowledge that belong to what he calls the absolute spirit or absolute knowledge. *Tosca* is set in Rome in 1800, at the time of the Battle of Marengo, the return of the Bourbons and the power of the Austrians, but also the possible return of the French and the Republic. Angelica Catalani, who sang in Rome during this period, could be a model for Floria Tosca in the power she wielded through her singing and beauty. But she differs from them in the destiny that was hers, in the affirmation of her power as an artist beyond political regimes. Catalani's song is a manifestation of the ideal, of the idea of beauty, but the Italian singer is also a manifestation of the absolute spirit, that is to say, of the awareness of freedom. In Hegel's system, female singers represent women, the power of music, the power of art, the consciousness of freedom, and also potentially the power of Italy and Italians against Austrian domination, in the struggle for independence and for the Republic, as in Puccini's opera.